



MONTHLY UPDATE

Southern Africa: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-02 · 14 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES · INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION ·
SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE · CAPACITY AND INCLUSION · FINANCE

Summary of the month

Southern Africa's month was dominated by handovers and workshops rather than instruments in force. [South Africa took the SADC chairpersonship at the 46th Ordinary Summit in Durban on 17 August](#), naming digital security among its priorities, while [SADC's own preparatory process for the 2027 World Radiocommunication Conference closed in Luanda on 7 August with harmonised common positions, text unpublished](#). COMESA ran parallel consultations on a regional AI strategy and a digital-inclusion strategy in Kigali, both still in drafting with no adoption route stated, and five customs administrations [adopted a roadmap for customs-to-customs data exchange in Pretoria](#). The secretariat's own figures to the Council of Ministers put [mobile penetration at 95.2%](#), already past the region's 2030 target, against [no member state meeting the 1% of GDP R&D-spending target](#).

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

[South Africa assumed the SADC chairpersonship from Zimbabwe at the 46th Ordinary Summit in Durban on 17 August](#), naming digital security among its strategic priorities alongside energy, water, industrialisation and regional infrastructure, and framing the year around accelerated implementation of SADC Vision 2050 and the Regional Indicative Strategic Development Plan. No work programme, budget or digital-security instrument accompanies the statement.

Southern Africa's preparatory process for the ITU's 2027 World Radiocommunication Conference reached its regional stage. A [third SADC preparatory meeting closed at Luanda on 7 August with harmonised SADC Common Positions and Proposals on key WRC-27 agenda items](#), spectrum allocation for International Mobile Telecommunications named as the sensitive debate; the position document itself is not published. The position travels next to the African preparatory meeting at Tunis, 7–11 September, ahead of WRC-27 in Shanghai.

CRASA, the regional telecommunications regulators' association, [held the first Finance, Risk and Audit Committee meeting of its 2026/27 financial year at Maseru on 20–21 August](#), reviewing financial and audit matters and assessing institutional risk across its regional programmes. No budget, audit opinion or risk register reaches the base from the account, which is a trade report of the association's own meeting.

Instruments and harmonisation

Standards

Polymakers, regulators and technical experts from eight Southern African states worked toward a roadmap for harmonising data-governance frameworks at a capacity-building workshop on 20 August, convened by a UN agency with a continental digital body and a member-state ministry, working from a data-governance toolkit and national self-assessments. The stated obstacles are fragmented frameworks, capacity gaps and uneven policy maturity; no roadmap text, adoption route or timetable is published.

AI

Two regional AI instruments moved in the same window, on different tracks. COMESA held a four-day stakeholder consultation in Kigali in August toward a regional AI strategy under the World Bank-supported IDEA programme, alongside a parallel digital-inclusion strategy; neither has a published draft, drafter or adoption route. SADC's own Regional Artificial Intelligence Strategy and Regulatory Framework is, by contrast, attested only by a member state rather than by the Secretariat: Malawi's ICT ministry described it as under development, and a regional workshop at Harare on data governance in the AI age — convened with the World Bank, a continental alliance and a UN agency — set out to harmonise member states' data policy for AI readiness. No Secretariat document on the framework is held.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

The Secretariat's own connectivity figures, given to the Council of Ministers in Durban on 12 August, put internet penetration at 57.2%, 4G population coverage at 79.2% and mobile penetration at 95.2% — the last already past the region's 2030 target. No member-state breakdown accompanies the figures.

A shared SADC satellite advanced procedurally: a technical submission on orbital positions was filed with the ITU and a financing working group created, reported 6 August, with the radiocommunication sector meeting to secure the slot. The project is described as at an early stage; no cost, launch date, operator or ITU filing reference is held.

Data Exchange

COMESA went to market for a Digital Information Knowledge and Collaboration Platform on 27 August, inviting technical and financial proposals under contract reference CS/CC/06/(846-2026); no budget, timetable or award reaches the base beyond the request itself — a procurement notice, not yet a system.

Five revenue administrations — Malawi, Mozambique, South Africa, Zambia and Zimbabwe — adopted a joint roadmap and action plan for customs-to-customs data exchange at a three-day Pretoria meeting hosted by the South African revenue service, closing 26 August. No delivery date is stated.

The incoming SADC chair also made one-stop border posts and digitised border systems a chairship priority at the 46th summit, tying them to a corridor trip-monitoring system integrating transport, immigration and customs data, online permitting and operator accreditation, one member's electronic visa and travel authorisation, and a proposed regional tourism visa — with progress to be measured in border-crossing times reduced rather than agreements signed. No baseline crossing time, target or timetable is published.

Capacity and inclusion

Research institutions

The Secretariat told the [Council of Ministers on 12 August](#) that no member state has reached the regional research-and-development spending target of 1% of GDP, or the continental target of 1.5%. No country-level figures accompany the statement.

Digital divides

COMESA's Regional Digital Inclusion Strategy is [in drafting under the same World Bank-supported IDEA programme and the same Kigali consultation as its AI strategy](#), covering affordable connectivity and devices, skills gaps, accessibility and digital trust. No draft, drafter or adoption date is published.

Finance

New investments

The UK [opened a call for expressions of interest on 11 August for a three-year Science and Technology Accelerator programme of up to GBP2.5m](#), covering artificial intelligence and emerging technologies and digital access and inclusion alongside climate, energy, health and space, with a primary focus on South Africa and a first-year focus on Zimbabwe and Zambia. No supplier, contract or start date is on record.

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